

—Jennifer, MI

5. GO IN ON A FAMILY PLAN

Sometimes being independent is overrated, particularly if you're talking about a cell phone plan. Just think about the number of commercials you've seen over the past week that offer exceptional deals for added cell phone lines! It's worth combining forces to reduce your overall monthly cost.

Joseph and I used to pay a whopping \$152 each month for both our smartphones, but saved \$35 just by hopping on the same plan as my parents and grandparents. We had absolutely no changes to our data usage or minutes either!

See if a few family members or relatives would be willing to do the same—even a group of close friends is a great option and results in savings for everyone. Just be sure to work out all the payment details ahead of time, and even sign a contract, if needed. You don't want to risk ruining a relationship when money is involved.

6. SWITCH SERVICES

Let's say you've done everything you can to stay with your current company, but it's still not enough. You might want to seriously consider switching services and research AT&T, Sprint, T-Mobile, or Verizon to see what they can offer you.

There are also lesser-known (no-contract) plans that are becoming more popular every day:

- **Straight Talk** offers unlimited talk, text, and data, and runs off the Sprint, AT&T, and Verizon networks, depending on the area. You can save more money the longer plan you purchase (e.g., 30-day plan vs. a 365-day plan).